

8 May 2026

Dear Editor,

Please find enclosed our revised manuscript for resubmission to PNAS. Once again, we thank all reviewers for taking their time to provide comments.

In response to Reviewer 2, we have now accounted for the variability observed in Hayden et al (NEJM, 2018) explicitly by performing Bayesian posterior sampling of the within-host parameters. As requested by the Editor, we have also toned down our conclusions.

We have detailed the revisions in a point-by-point response. Beyond the requested revisions, we have also edited the manuscript to improve readability. We have provided a track-changed version of the manuscript highlighting all modifications.

We hope the revised manuscript meets the standards for publication and look forward to your decision.

Sincerely,

Alvin X. Han, Katina D. Hulme and Colin A. Russell